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Manchester

Ethics

Understanding Ethics as a discipline in an age of disagreement

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What is Ethics?

- The study of Right and Wrong
- Understanding the nature of “The Good”
- Answering the question “What should I do?”
- Answering the question “What does it mean to be a good person?”

But how to address those matters is highly contested…

How do you know what is right or good?

Are some things simply right (or wrong) of themselves ?

(Deontological ethics)

But who says so?

Or are things good because they lead to good outcomes?

(Consequentialist ethics)

But how do we know what is a good outcome?

Three phases of history

- Pre-Modern - ‘Tribal’ societies - whole ways of life taken to be ‘Normal’
- Modern - The search for universal rational ethics – since rationality is the common distinguishing feature of human beings.
- Post-modern - Breakdown of universalism. Breakdown of shared assumptions and shared institutions. Breakdown of consensus about how to determine truth.



Is this what ethical disagreement looks like today?



The Problem …

Modernity developed mechanisms to help societies arrive at agreed positions:

- - the ballot box (the majority determines the outcome)
- - the market place (value is determined in terms of monetary exchange)
- - the Law (administered separately from the political sphere)

BUT

- - the outcome of ballots can leave minorities disenfranchised
- the market doesn't reflect some things which people in general believe to be important (e.g. community solidarity; donation of blood or organs.)
- - decisions by the courts are increasingly contested by the 'losers' – and the balance of authority between law and politics is being challenged by politicians….

So how does this impact on AI Ethics?

- AI is mostly being developed and rolled out in cultures where the ballot, the market and the law are the mechanisms for making moral decisions.

BUT if these mechanisms are not working, what sort of AI will we get?

WHOSE ethical principles will shape the AI applications that affect everyone's lives?

Examples….

1. AI and Weapon systems.

- Different cultures have different “ethics of the battlefield” (e.g. whether it is justified to shoot prisoners; whether it is justified to wipe out villages which might harbour snipers etc.)

- Both those examples can be justified consequentially – shooting prisoners releases your own troops to be on the front line (and saves resources): Wiping out the village before entering it could save many of your own side’s lives. But both are regarded as War Crimes in many cultures.

- “Just War” ethics treats lethal weapons as, first, deterrents, secondly as defensive – which means they must be efficient at killing only *if necessary*. So how is that ethics built into an AI weapon system?

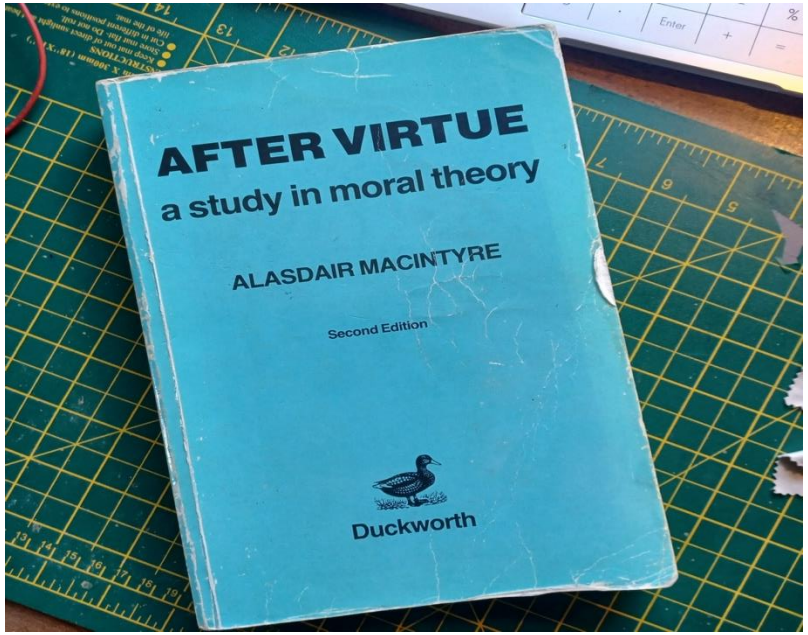
Example 2.

- **Whose culture is embedded in AI?**

- The 19th and 20th Century models of Imperialism attempted to impose a specific kind of Western culture on other peoples.
- If AI applications are designed by people from a very limited range of cultural backgrounds (Silicon Valley, perhaps? Mega-rich Tech Barons?) and marketed globally…. **Is this a new imperialism?**

A different approach

- One trend in Ethics (at least in the academy) over the last 40 years is known as Virtue Ethics.
- What does it mean to be a good person?
- Key text: Alasdair MacIntyre: *After Virtue* (1981)



Key Questions in Virtue Ethics

How do I learn to be a good person?

Through being part of a community which has traditions, stories (narratives) and practices.

Instead of asking, "What should I do?" ask,

"Of what story or stories am I a part?"

What does it mean to be a good doctor? – a good architect?

– a good AI designer??

If Ethics focusses on being a good person…

- How do we understand “Being Human”? - especially in the context of AI interacting with human persons.

- Is the key question:

  How like a human can/should we make AI applications?

OR

  How can we build AI which treat US as fully human?

How we might think about machine intelligence…

"Intelligence is not about being human, but about being able to behave effectively in new situations. This ability does not require a brain: we can find it also in plants, ant colonies and software. Different agents can display this ability to different extents in different tasks: there is not a single general way to be intelligent, nor a secret formula or a single test. It is misleading to attribute human qualities to all intelligent agents, and when reflecting on the intelligences we encounter in our browsers we would do better by comparing them with the snails and herbs in our garden, rather than with us."

Prof Nello Christianini, University of Bath.
The Shortcut: Why Intelligent Machines Do Not Think Like Us.
Taylor and Francis, 2023.

Ethics and Being Human

How human beings practice the good – and how can it be incorporated into machines and systems which take on human functions?

Adam Smith, *Wealth of Nations*, 1776

"It is not from the benevolence of the butcher, the brewer or the baker, that we expect our dinner, but from their regard to their own interest."



… but, says MacIntyre,

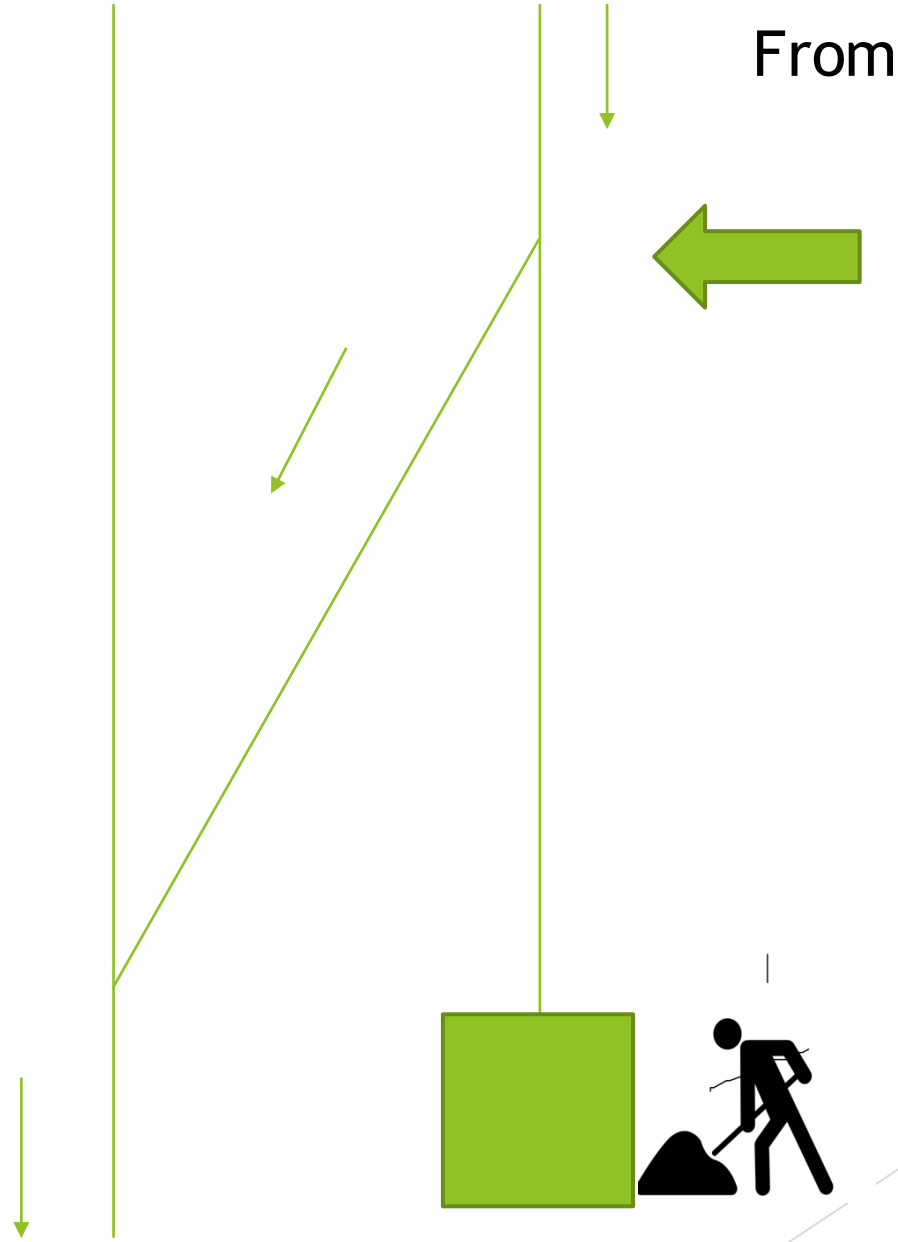
If I go into the butcher's shop and find the butcher having a heart attack, and I just say, "Oh. Not in a position to sell me my meat today, I see", and go elsewhere, I am deficient as a human being although I have done nothing to break the principle of the market which Adam Smith outlines.

From Buxton



Towards Manchester
Gradient: 1 in 58

From Buxton



Towards Manchester



Who do we take account of in moral reasoning?

- Self.
- Known persons - e.g. Office holders, Contract holders
- Hypothetical Others – who may or may not exist

- Private Goods
- Public Goods

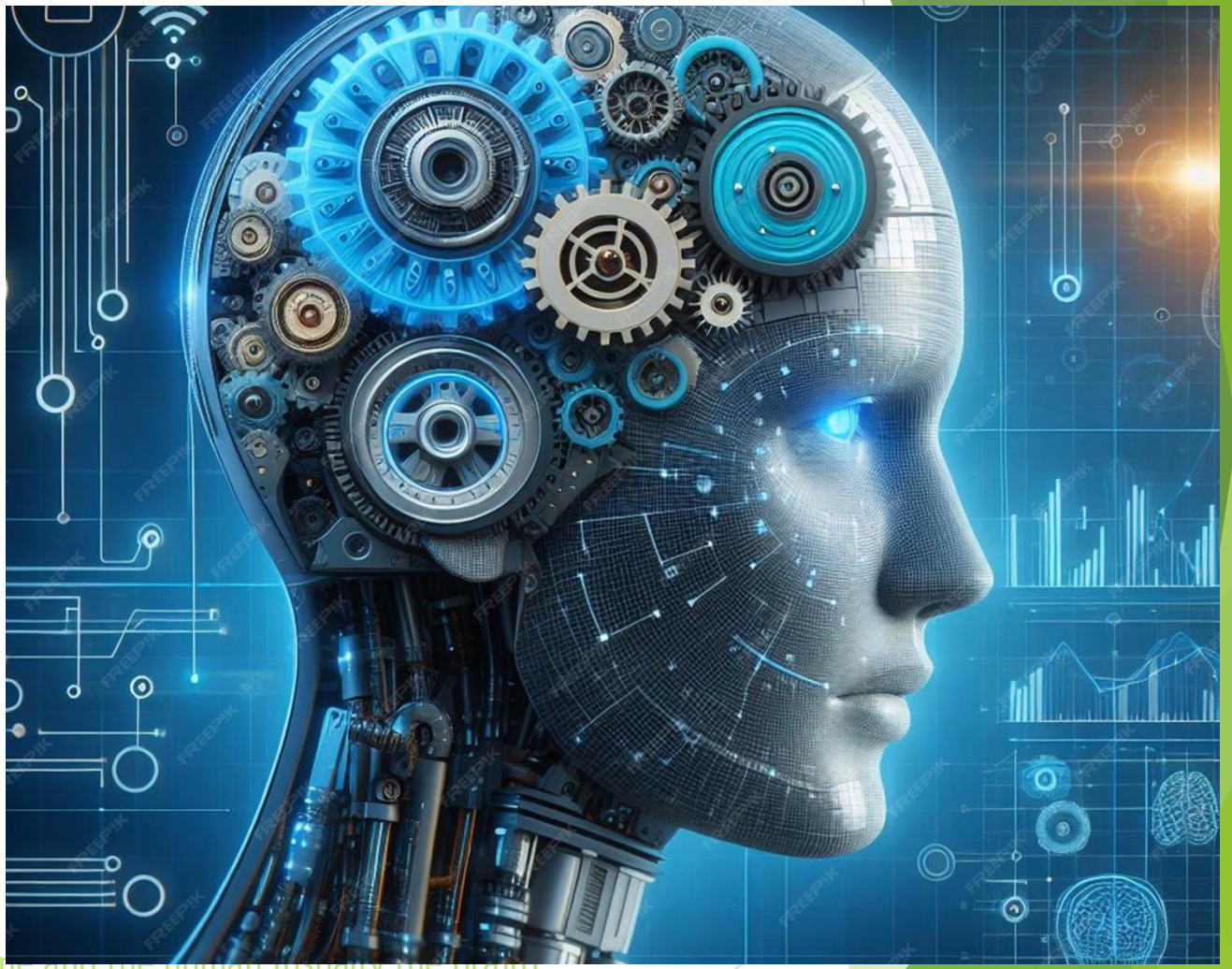
Three key ideas

- Supererogation : Performance of more than duty or circumstances require (OED)
- Moral Formation : How people come to know what is good.
- The Common Good : (Aquinas) Goods that benefit all - including such things as **protecting life, preserving the state, and promoting the peace**. Aristotle would have called this "the good life."

3 Questions for Ethics in AI

- Can machines, algorithms etc being developed in a culture of market economics ever incorporate considerations like supererogation which don't fit a rules-based understanding of ethics?
- Who decides the ethic that controls the decisions of the machine? (Are drone weapons programmed to kill first or to ask questions first?)
- What is the dominant metaphor for what we are doing with AI? (Is it a tool? A brain? A disembodied intelligence? The perfection of reason?)

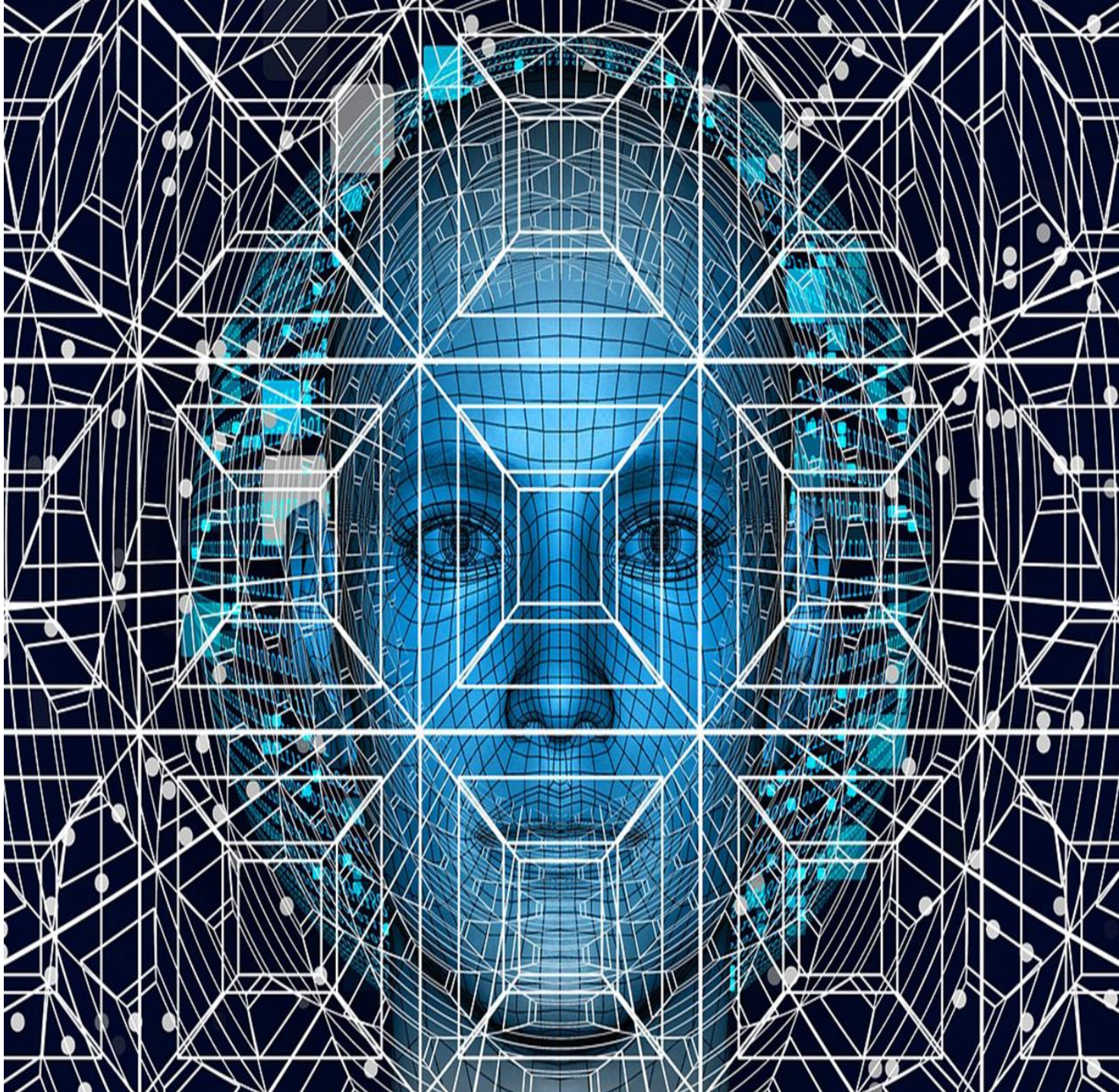
The Images We Use Matter….



The vast majority of stock images of “AI” merge the machine and the human (usually the brain)

AI as Vast Quantities of Data

(Not an easy concept to show as a picture)



Being Human…

- **Embodied** (therefore vulnerable and finite)

- *"Dependent Rational Animals"*(MacIntyre)

- But also capable of experiencing:

  Joy

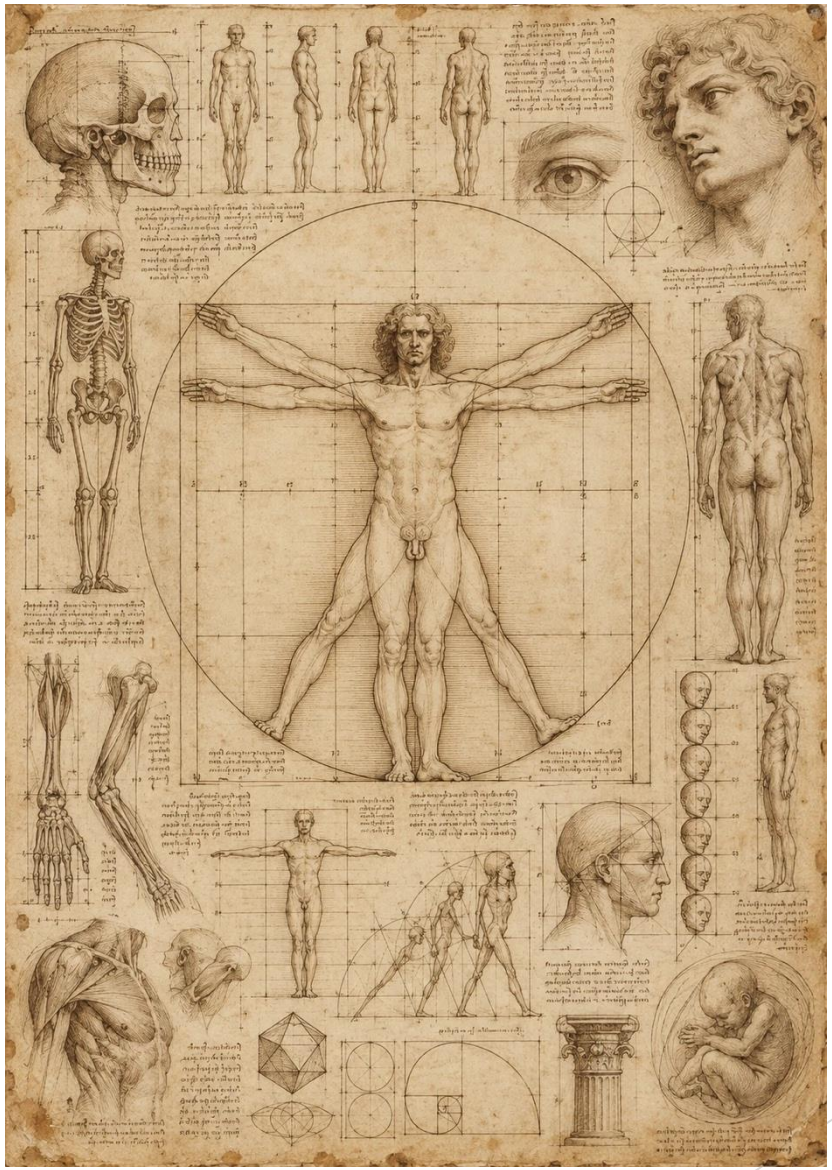
  Fear

  Love

  Transcendence

  Pain

  Wonder…



Avoid reductionist models of the human person!

How we might think about machine intelligence…

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